

### Unwavering focus:

Batra of India in action against Miu Hirano of Japan in the women's pre-quarterfinal match on July 31. RITU RAJ KONWAR

**A place in an Olympic quarterfinal for an Indian was something that even an ardent table tennis fan would have found hard to believe until recently.**

another feather in his string of records — but he was also India's flagbearer at the opening ceremony.

The 42-year-old couldn't translate it into a memorable outing on the table, losing in the round of 64 in his maiden singles match. More than the premature exit, the manner in which the 24th seed was found wanting against Slovenia's Deni Kožul, placed 86 places below Sharath in the world rankings, was disappointing.

Harmeet Desai, the other male singles paddler, had a respectable outing on his Olympic debut. He asked a few questions of eventual bronze medallist Felix LeBrun of France before bowing out in the

second round. Contrary to women, who had a favourable draw, India's men were pitted against mighty China first up in the team championship. But Sharath left his mark on his last Olympic hurrah by snatching a game from singles gold medallist Fan Zhendong. Even Harmeet and Manav Thakkar in doubles and the latter in his singles outing demonstrated that Indian table tennis has indeed come a long way from merely taking pride in representing India at the Olympics.

But the fortnight belonged to India's women, especially the duo of Manika and Sreeja. They may appear in stark contrast to each other. While Manika is among the tallest female paddlers on the world circuit, Sreeja is on the shorter side. But the Indian duo bears a resemblance in effectively using their long-pimpled rubber on the backhand. Moreover, both of them have mastered the trickery of flipping the rubber between the points to bamboozle the majority of their opponents.

No wonder then that Sreeja, having overtaken Manika in the world rankings weeks before the Olympics, was handed the 16th seed, with Manika not too far behind.

Naturally, Manika faced the first big test before Sreeja, as she was up against local sensation Prithika Pavade. The southpaw not only enjoyed the French crowd support but also rode high on the confidence of being the star of France's bronze medal-winning run in the World Championship. But Manika, who had controversially played without a coach behind her in Tokyo three years ago, along with national coach Massimo Costantini's timely guidance, ensured she didn't let a boisterous crowd get to her by running away with a 4-0 win. The only time Manika stuttered was when Prithika saved three match points in the fourth game.

Up next was the eighth seed, Miu Hirano, but the Japanese edged past Manika to halt her run. Despite losing in the pre-quarterfinals, Manika's third Olympic appearance — a first for an Indian female paddler — was her most successful



**Women take a W:** Manika Batra celebrates with her teammates after winning the singles match against Romania at the South Paris Arena. AFP

outing.

Sreeja, on the other hand, not only soaked up the atmosphere on her Olympic debut but also justified her billing. After an easy opening round, Sreeja was hardly troubled by seasoned Christina Kallberg of Sweden in the round of 64. Then she beat 31st seed, Singapore's Zeng Jian to set a clash with top seed, Sun Yingsha of China. The scoreline may end up reading 4-0 in favour of the eventual silver medallist, but had Sreeja been able to convert at least one of the nine game points she enjoyed over the first two games combined, she may have scripted history by ousting a Chinese paddler, a rarity in Olympic table tennis. But the duo delivered along with Archana as India overcame fancied Romania in the women's team championship pre-quarterfinal 3-2. While Manika won both her singles, the other two paired to snatch the doubles.

Annett Kaufmann, the teenage southpaw, then wielded her magic in the quarterfinal to end India's hopes of featuring in a medal match for the first time in the Olympics.

Nevertheless, despite being far from the podium, it turned out to be India's most successful Olympic table tennis outing, primarily thanks to its female paddlers.